

“If Danone wants to be a global leader, it must be big in India”

Danone CEO Antoine de Saint-Affrique on the company's game plan for India, technology, and much more

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32 |

Antoine de Saint-Affrique took charge as Danone's CEO in September 2021. Globally, the €27.6-billion company has three businesses—essential dairy and plant-based products, specialised nutrition, and waters. It is present in the specialised nutrition space in India with brands such as Protinex, Aptamil, and Dexolac. Danone recently launched a three-year programme to equip more than 5,000 dairy farmers in Punjab with sustainable methods to help increase milk yields. de Saint-Affrique, 59, speaks to *Business Today's Krishna Gopalan* on a host of issues including the company's sustainable growth plan, Renew Danone, the debate on plant-based products, and why India matters. Edited excerpts:

Q: How does it feel to be back in Danone?

A: I first worked in Danone before it was acquired by Unilever, where I then spent 15 years. In fact, this is my third stint with Danone. The first was an internship as a student before going to the navy. This is a homecoming, and I believe this is a company that is unique in many different ways. We are large but care about not just the business but the world around us.

Q: In March 2022, you presented Renew Danone, a strategic plan around four pillars (win where we are, expand where we should be, seed the future and manage the portfolio). What was the rationale?

A: Danone was going through challenging times at that point (activist shareholders managed to oust the company's then Chairman & CEO Emmanuel Faber). The name of the game was to bring calm and focus. The board was completely changed as was a large part of the executive committee. The focus was on brands and profitability, meaning we had to reinvent. Brands [were to be] at the centre of the company and [whatever we did, we had to] be obsessive about execution.

We have been blessed with a large stable of brands. I decided to bring back science to the heart of the operation. There is a depth of knowledge, and we had to capitalise on that. Danone is a company of passionate people, even those who don't work for us anymore. Earlier this year, I was at the home where Van Gogh [lived] in France. The owner of the house discovered I worked with Danone and said he worked for the company 35 years ago. I had the most exclusive visit eventually!

Q: What was the mandate when you took over?

A: I wanted to bring Danone to its rightful place and that was to make it shine again and bring it back on